VISHAL CHATURVEDI

# SPIRITUAL SON

**This sleeper blockbuster of 2026** was written on a notebook stamped with the Marvel Comics logo. In his compact office in Andheri, Mumbai, Vishal Chaturvedi, writer-director-co-producer of *Hanuman Ansh*, flips through the book, amazed that his low-budget film about a spiritual guru would rival collections of a superhero flick. It's from this office that his team edited the film, designed the posters and did more than half of the visual effects. "I had become stubborn when it came to making *Hanuman Ansh*," says Chaturvedi.

A doctor-turned-self-taught filmmaker, Chaturvedi first heard of spiritual leader Neem Karoli in 2006 on a road trip with friends in Uttarakhand. Riding in dense fog, their car skidded off the road and stopped in front of the gate of Kainchi dham, the site popular among his devotees. So began his journey to know more about the guru. Gradually, Chaturvedi was convinced that Baba's life was ripe for a film. Before the script, he self-published a book on the guru, *The Divine Detour*.

**"Villains in shows have a certain attire, wear *tilak* and *kalavaah*.... Why can't a *tilakdhaari vyakti* be a hero of the film?" asks Vishal**

Finding producers to back his vision was a challenge—this despite a resume full of music videos and ad films, as creator on *Fauji 2* and creative producer on multiple films. An OTT platform turned Chaturvedi down, but it was their manner that stayed with Chaturvedi. "They said, 'We are not looking for *such* kinds of stories'."

*Hanuman Ansh*'s success lies in its clean storytelling: anecdotes of the Baba's life blended with his ideology. "He is trying to make people better not by telling them 'give me gold' or 'touch my feet'," he says. "Instead, he says, 'Love everyone, Ram Ram *likho aur bolo*, *bhookon ko bhojan do*, *bhakton ko prasad*'."

The film is the gift that keeps on giving. Chaturvedi already has a producer for his next, a devotional drama on saint-poet Tulsidas. *Hanuman Ansh* producers are keen for a part II. He is keeping streaming platforms waiting on digital rights, including the one that shunned him. ■



MANDAR DEODHAR

### *Hanuman Ansh*

**Director:** *Vishal Chaturvedi*

**Producers:** *Chaturvedi, Ragini Sona, Namrata Singh & Anupriya Nagar*

**Date of release:** *Part I in theatres, Part II (TBA)*

**On a shoestring budget of Rs 1.7 crore, this biopic of Neem Karoli Baba has rewritten box-office rules by picking up steam in week three and collecting Rs 400 crore. Writer-director Chaturvedi isn't done; he will present more of the guru's legends in Part II.**